connecting China with Central Asia, Russia, and Europe. By connecting up with the BRI corridors in Central Asia, INSTC would open up the BRI for the use of countries other than China. In the long term, it may also serve the strategic interests of the United States and its allies to connect with Afghanistan and Central Asia without having to go through the territory of Russia.

Russia is a permanent member of the UN Security Council with a veto, which it has used in the past to India's benefit. This was particularly valuable during the Cold War era, when India had major differences with the West on its core concerns relating to Pakistan and Jammu and Kashmir. With the post–Cold War strategic partnerships with the United States and other western countries, such situations are now less likely to arise. However, Russia's support on issues of importance to India does strengthen India's position. Russia's support for India's membership of the NSG, though China strongly opposed it, is one example. A more telling case was Russia's reaction to India's constitutional amendments on the status of Jammu and Kashmir in August 2019. Though China moved for a discussion on this in the UN Security Council, Russia took an unequivocal public position that this was an internal Indian matter. The Russian Ministry of Foreign Affairs confirmed that the Russian Foreign Minister had confirmed this to his Pakistani counterpart.[27]

For India, the considerations outlined previously make it politically costly to dilute its relations with Russia under pressure from the United States. The concept of an exclusive alliance with the United States is not applicable in India's geopolitical situation. A geographically distant ally cannot be an effective bulwark against two large geographically proximate adversaries, as Russia and China would surely be if India were to become an American ally. Invoking CAATSA would derail India's efforts towards